

What Would This Cost a Real Studio?

A War Without Victory — Development Cost Analysis

Date: 15 March 2026

Version: v0.3.0 (Playable Alpha)

What Has Been Built

- **Simulation engine** — 140 pipeline steps, full combat resolution, supply, morale, cohesion, fatigue, entrenchment, equipment
- **247 brigades** — Historically researched OOB across 3 factions, named officers with succession and war crimes records
- **Desktop application** — Electron with warroom HQ screens, tactical map, save/load system, panel rail UI
- **643 tests** — 61 suites, determinism-verified, war termination, alliance lifecycle, officer system
- **3-tier AI** — Army/Corps/Brigade with doctrine, operations, 5-phase preparation, intel-gated decisions
- **Map/GIS pipeline** — 744 operational settlements, PMTiles terrain, MapLibre tactical map with 7 overlay modes
- **Historical data** — Census demographics, Balkan Battlegrounds citations, calibration achieving 90%+ accuracy
- **620 documents** — Versioned canon (v0.7), engineering specs, ADRs, reports, knowledge base

Studio Team Estimate

A real studio would need this team to build what exists today:

ROLE	FTES	RESPONSIBILITY
Game Designer / Lead	1	Systems design, historical research, balance
Systems Programmer	2	Simulation engine, AI, determinism, pipeline
UI/UX Developer	1	React, Electron, MapLibre integration
GIS / Map Engineer	1	Tile pipeline, polygon toolchain, spatial data
QA / Test Engineer	1	643 tests, calibration runs, determinism verification
Historian / Content	1	OOB research, BB extraction, scenario authoring
Technical Writer	0.5	620 documents, canon system, versioning
Producer / PM	0.5	Roadmap, backlog, coordination
Total	~8	12–18 months to reach this point

Cost Estimate

EUROPEAN STUDIO

€675K

8 FTEs × 15 months
€5,500/month avg

US-BASED STUDIO

\$1.1M

8 FTEs × 15 months
\$8,500/month avg

AAA STUDIO

€2.5M

12–15 people
+ overhead, office, mgmt

ITEM	MID-TIER EUROPEAN
Personnel (8 FTEs × 15 months × €5,500)	€660,000
Tools, infrastructure, licenses	€15,000
Historical source material	€2,000
Total	~€675,000

How It Was Actually Built

This was built by **one person + AI tooling** over roughly **8 weeks of intensive work** (late January to mid-March 2026).

The AI performs the work of approximately 5–6 of those 8 roles simultaneously:

- Systems Programming
- UI Development
- Test Writing
- Documentation
- Historical Research
- QA & Calibration

Studio-equivalent value of AI contribution: **€400,000–500,000** of engineering and content work compressed into 8 weeks.

The thing no studio could replicate is the **design coherence**. Having one person's vision driving everything — with an AI that remembers 620 documents of context — means zero design-by-committee drift. That's worth more than the engineering savings.

Hi, Haris's wife. He's not crazy. This is a real game and it's actually impressive.

"Another such victory and we are undone."